
The World's Oldest
ALPHABET

ALPHABETIC CHART OF PROTO-CONSONANTAL HEBREW

Hebrew Block-Letter	Projected Proto-Hebrew Original Letter	Middle-Egyptian Hieroglyphic Exemplar (Sign-List Number)	Original Hebrew Alphabetic Name (NIVEC Number)	Hebrew Consonantals of Middle Kingdom (ca. 1842–1760 BC)	Hebrew Consonantals of New Kingdom (ca. 1560–1307 BC)	Hebrew Consonantals of Iron Age - Canaan (ca. 1150–587 BC)
א		 (F1)	<i>ʿelef</i> cattle אֵלֶף (477)	 Sinai 377 W. el-H. 1 W. el-H. 2	 Sinai 349 Sinai 359 Sinai 375c	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Qayafa O.
ב	 Sinai 92, 405	 (O1)  (O4)	<i>bayit</i> house בֵּית (1074)	 Sinai 115 W. el-H. 1 W. el-H. 2 Lahun O.	 Gezer Pot. Sinai 349 Sinai 362 Sinai 364	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Qayafa O.
ג	 Sinai 112	 (O38)	<i>gāhar</i> bend גָּהָר (1566)	 W. el-H. 1 W. el-H. 2 Lahun O.	 Sinai 357 Sinai 375a Lachish Prism	 Sarrab O. Siloam In. Gibeon J.
ד		 (O31)	<i>delet</i> door דֶּלֶת (1946)	 Sinai 376	 Sinai 353 Sinai 362 Sinai 367	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Gibeon J.
ה	 Sinai 92	 (A28)	<i>hālal</i> praise הָלַל (2146)	 W. el-H. 1 W. el-H. 2 Lahun O.	 Sinai 345a Sinai 362 Sinai 374	 Sarrab O. Siloam In. Gibeon J.
ו		 (O30)	<i>wāw</i> pillar-support וָו (2260)	 W. el-H. 1 W. el-H. 2 Lahun O.	 Gezer Potsherd Sinai 345a Sinai 351 Sinai 353	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Siloam In. Gibeon J.
ז		 (D13)	<i>zēʾāh</i> sweat (brows) זָעָה (2399)	 Lahun O. (MB IIc)	 Sinai 349 Sinai 361 Lachish P.	 Sarrab O. Siloam In. Gibeon J.
ח	 Sinai 405	 (O6)  (V28)	<i>hāšēr</i> enclosure חָשֶׁר (2958) <i>hūt</i> thread חוּט (2562)	 Lahun O. W. el-H. 1 W. el-H. 2	 Sinai 349 Sinai 353 Sinai 361	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Ophel In. Barash B.
ט	 Sinai 112	 (F35)	<i>tōv</i> good טוֹב (3201)		 Sinai 351	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Siloam In.
י	 Sinai 405 Sinai 92	 (D36)  (D47)	<i>yād</i> hand יָד (3338)	 W. el-H. 2 Lahun O. Sinai 376 (MB IIc) Lachish D.	 Sinai 345b Sinai 353 Sinai 364	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Ophel In. Siloam In.
כ	 Sinai 92	 (D28)	<i>kap</i> palm כַּף (4090)	 W. el-H. 2 W. el-H. 2 Lahun O.	 Gezer Pot. Sinai 349 Sinai 353 Sinai 361	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Ophel In.
ל	 Sinai 92	 (S39)	<i>lāmad</i> teach לָמַד (4340) לָמַד (4913)	 Sinai 377 W. el-H. 2 Lahun O.	 Sinai 349 Sinai 353 Sinai 361	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Ophel In.
מ	 Sinai 405	 (N35)	<i>mayim</i> water מַיִם (4784)	 Sinai 377 W. el-H. 1 W. el-H. 2	 Sinai 349 Sinai 353 Sinai 375a	 Qayafa O. Ophel In. Siloam In.
נ	 Sinai 87	 (I9)  (I10)	<i>nāḥāš</i> snake נָחָשׁ (5729)	 W. el-H. 1 W. el-H. 2 Lahun O. Sinai 376	 Sinai 346b Sinai 349 Sinai 360	 Qayafa O. Ophel In. Barash B. Siloam In.
ס	 Sinai 90	 (D3)  (K5)	<i>šēʾār</i> hair סִשְׁעָר (8482) <i>sārah</i> stink סָרַח (6244)	 W. el-H. 1 W. el-H. 2 Sinai 376 Lachish D.	 Sinai 351 Sinai 346a Sinai 353	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Ophel In. Lachish I.
ע	 Sinai 92	 (D4)	<i>ʿayin</i> eye עֵין (6523)	 W. el-H. 2 Sinai 376 Lachish D.	 Sinai 346a Sinai 349 Sinai 353	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Siloam In.
פ	 Sinai 92	 (D21)	<i>peh</i> mouth פֶּה (7023)	 Sinai 377 W. el-H. 1	 Sinai 349 Sinai 349 Sinai 375a	 Lachish J. Sarrab O. Siloam In.
צ		 (V33)	<i>šarōr</i> sack צָרוּר (7655)	© 2015 Douglas Petrovich	 Sinai 346b Sinai 349 Sinai 351	 Sarrab O. Siloam In. Lachish I.
ק		 (V25)	<i>qūr</i> spun-fiber קוּר (7770)	 Sinai 376	 Sinai 349 Sinai 351	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Ophel In.
ר	 Sinai 405	 (D1)	<i>roš</i> head רֹאשׁ (8031)	 W. el-H. 1 Lahun O. Sinai 376	 Lachish D. Sinai 353 Sinai 357	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Siloam In.
ש		 (D27)	<i>šādayim</i> breasts שְׂדַיִם (8716)		 Sinai 349 Sinai 353 Sinai 357	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Siloam In.
ת	 Sinai 92	 (M42)	<i>tayiš</i> male goat תַּיִשׁ (9411)	 W. el-H. 2 W. el-H. 2 Sinai 376	 Sinai 349 Sinai 351 Lachish P.	 Sarrab O. Qayafa O. Siloam In.

Fig. 1.

DOUGLAS PETROVICH

The World's Oldest ALPHABET

HEBREW AS THE LANGUAGE OF THE
PROTO-CONSONANTAL SCRIPT

WITH A CONTRIBUTION BY

SARAH K. DOHERTY

&

INTRODUCTION BY

EUGENE H. MERRILL

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INTRODUCTION

The origin of the alphabet has been a matter of intense interest from time immemorial. The primitive pictographic and cumbersome syllabic forms of written communication that originated in the latter case at least as early as 3200 BC gave way at some point to the incredibly facile and flexible development of alphabets, an advancement dated and attributed to a variety of times and places. The search for the beginnings of alphabetic scripts has borne fruit in the past century or so with focus particularly on the ancient Eastern Mediterranean world. Biblical scholars have been at the forefront of these endeavors since the texts of sacred scriptures have never been evinced, except in alphabetic form, though the assumption is well-nigh universal that the existing exemplars likely sprang from both oral and written traditions, perhaps, in the latter case, non-alphabetically.

The assumption just made must remain somewhat tentative to this point, given the dearth of archaeological support. However, if one grants the antiquity of the written Hebrew tradition in line with that of cultures surrounding the Levant, nothing should stand in the way of positing analogously the existence of Hebrew writings also composed in pre-alphabetic form. Putting this line of thought to the side, the focus of Professor Petrovich's work is not so much on theories about Hebrew pre-alphabetic literature as on the antiquity of the Hebrew alphabetic tradition itself. Indeed, his thesis is that the Hebrew alphabet was not only early, but the earliest of all, the progenitor of all alphabets and alphabetic writing!

Important to his thesis is the irrefutable fact that the use by scribes of alphabetic notations is attested to from a number of sites, exclusively so far to the ancient Near East. Very early movements along this line are seen in both cuneiform syllabic and Egyptian proto-alphabetic signs as visual precursors to the consonants. In the former instance, Denise Schmandt-Besserat brilliantly decoded the so-called "tokens" and "envelopes" of the Sumerian site of Uruk IV B (ca. 3200 BC) and ascribed phonetic value to these varied shaped objects, prototypes inevitably leading to alphabetic systems, if not in Mesopotamia itself, at least elsewhere.¹ As for Egypt, the turquoise mines of Serâbît

1 Denise Schmandt-Besserat, "An Archaic Recording System in the Uruk-Jemdet Nasr Period," *AJA* 83/1 (1979), p. 25; *Before Writing, Volume I: From Counting to Cuneiform*. Austin, TX: University of Texas Press, 1992; *Before Writing, Volume II: A Catalog of Near Eastern Tokens*. Austin, TX: University of Texas Press, 1992; *How Writing Came About*. Austin, TX: University of Texas Press, 1996. Sumerian and Akkadian never achieved a true alphabetic scheme, but through a process of phoneticism>syllabification>alphabeticism, it prepared the way for such a development in NW Semitic (e.g., Ugaritic, Phoenician, Aramaic, and eventually Hebrew). See I. J. Gelb, *A Study of Writing*. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1974, pp. 204–205.

el Khadîm² (ca. 1850 BC) in the Sinai and Wadi el-Ḥîl³ (ca. 1800) yielded inscriptions whose characters were modified so as to result in a practicable alphabet. No one has done more to recognize this fact and to present its scholarly defense than Douglas Petrovich.

Ras Shamra (Ugarit, ca. 1350 BC) on the northern Mediterranean coast of modern Syria is another example of an alphabetic script and discrete Semitic dialect, but this is a late-comer compared to those just listed. The adaptability of the “shorthand” of alphabets soon became evident to civilizations near and far, and by 1100 had become utilized and exported by the Phoenicians to Greece and Crete and over time to Italy and Rome, in which places the great Greek and Latin classics came to be composed.

The breakthrough as to the question of the origins of the alphabet represented in this volume is the fruit of the author’s intensive and extensive research and fastidious attention to detail. His acclaimed expertise in epigraphy, palaeography, lexicography, and comparative linguistics and literature has led him to the conviction that of all options one can currently advance as to the ultimate origins of the alphabet, the identification of proto-Hebrew is the very best candidate. Careful perusal of this volume will almost certainly persuade the reader of the validity of Petrovich’s methods and conclusions. One can anticipate the objection that Hebrew works best for the author because of his ideological and / or theological predilections regarding the Bible and all things religious, but such an objection is undermined by the disciplined way in which, by process of elimination, he discredits other contenders, on the one hand, and, on the other hand, builds a solid case for Hebrew as the only alternative by virtue of all the criteria necessary to its certification as the pioneer, as it were, in the long and convoluted train of Semitic cognate and non-Semitic heirs to the alphabetic tradition.

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November 2016

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- 2 The mines are ca. 50 km NW of Mount Sinai. See W. F. Albright, “The Early Alphabetic Inscriptions from Sinai and Their Decipherment,” *BASOR* 110 (1948): 6–22; I. J. Gelb, *A Study of Writing*. Rev. ed. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1962, pp. 122–128; Joseph Naveh, *Origins of the Alphabets*. Jerusalem: Jerusalem Publishing House, 1994, pp. 14–17. James K. Hoffmeier, *Ancient Israel in Sinai: The Evidence for the Authenticity of the Wilderness Tradition*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2011.
- 3 This site is ca. 40 km NW of Luxor / Karnak, 55 km SE of Abydos, and 15 km west of the Nile River. See John C. Darnell, F. W. Dobbs-Allsopp, Marilyn J. Lundberg, P. Kyle McCarter, Bruce Zuckerman, and Colleen Manassa, “Two Early Alphabetic Inscriptions from the Wadi el-Ḥîl: New Evidence for the Origin of the Alphabet from the Western Desert of Egypt,” *AASOR* 59 (2005): 90.

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EGYPT AND SINAI



PREFACE

This book is dedicated to Hubert Grimme, who first and correctly proposed that Hebrew is the language of the proto-consonantal script, and to every scholar who came before me in the study of this amazing field, without whose underappreciated contributions I certainly could not have made mine.

“Truth is unkillable!” – Balthasar Hübmaier

This volume represents the culmination of an enormous amount of research and the unlikely but groundbreaking discovery of the language behind the world’s oldest alphabet, which by no means was a goal that I had set out to accomplish. Since at least the third quarter of the nineteenth century, scholars in the field of both Egyptology and Western Semitic languages have attempted to isolate the proper Semitic language of the elusive proto-consonantal script, which is attested at Egyptian sites such as Wadi el-Ḥôl, Lahun, and—with the most voluminous amount of witnesses—Sinai’s Serâbîṭ el-Khâdim. The earliest texts discussed in scholarly literature of the nineteenth century are those from the turquoise mines at Serâbîṭ.

The challenge not only was to identify the correct language of the script, which primarily was written only with consonants (i.e. without vowels), but to decipher each pictographic letter correctly. As a result, the consonantal value of some letters has been agreed upon by scholars from early on, while that of other letters has remained in dispute. The matter is complicated by a number of factors, including the poorly preserved surfaces of many of the inscriptions, the often-times poorly executed forms of letters that cannot always be identified as to the specific pictograph (i.e. “images depicting words, syllables, or letters”; see Yardeni 2014: 3) that the ancient writer intended to inscribe, and the variety of ways in which letters were drawn by the authors of the PCH (proto-consonantal Hebrew) inscriptions of antiquity.

As a result of the unmet challenges presented by the daunting task of deciphering the world’s oldest alphabet, many radical thoughts have been expressed within this narrow field of study. While the reader will be spared from exposure to this checkered past, one set of comments is worth noting. A recent author wrongly remarked that the writings of the proto-consonantal script *were not language in a formal sense*, because the alphabet did not yet belong to an institution with the will to formalize it (Sanders 2009: 49). He also misdeclared that compared to the corpus of Sumero-Akkadian texts, the Wadi el-Ḥôl inscriptions are typical graffiti. Instead, they are highly poetical, represent advanced grammatical structure, and are dripping with profound meaning. The reality is that the study of the proto-consonantal writings has advanced greatly over the decades, and now that its language and script have been deciphered—perhaps fully, though only time will tell—unwarranted derogatory statements such as those of Sanders now can be laid to rest forever. The PCH texts *absolutely* are language in a formal sense.

To date, the most important work in the field has been Gordon Hamilton’s 2006 book, *The Origins of the West Semitic Alphabet in Egyptian Scripts*, which is an expanded and updated version of his dissertation. Before that, the standard work was Benjamin Sass’s

The Genesis of the Alphabet and Its Development in the Second Millennium B.C. of 1988, also the fruit of this scholar's doctoral dissertation. The most glaring weakness with both books, to which I nonetheless am deeply indebted on many levels, is the lack of virtually any attempt to translate the inscriptions that were documented. This lamentable situation obviously begins with their lack of knowledge of the proper Semitic language of the script, which reflects the greater criticism that few scholars, with the possible but doubtful exception of Hubert Grimme in the 1920s, have attempted to follow the archaeological trail that would have led them to the correct language.

This criticism reflects the virtual chasm that divides epigraphers from archaeologists. Progress will come only with interdisciplinary training and greater interaction with those of the opposite specialization. The criticism about the failure to identify the proper Semitic language of the script can be tempered by the difficulty with correctly identifying all of the intended pictographs in the various inscriptions, the lack of agreement as to the phonetic value of each pictograph, and the damaged state of many of the inscriptions. Yet despite all of these disclaimers, the fact remains that over recent decades, scholarly drawings and publications of many of the inscriptions have worsened—rather than improved—from those drawn by an earlier generation of scholars, such as with the published drawings of Sinai 349, Sinai 351, and Sinai 375a.

Therefore, the lack of energy that has been exerted to identify the language of the script and translate the inscriptions has been rivaled by the recent lack of effort to provide accurate drawings of all of the pictographs on many of the inscriptions, and thus to render all of the inscriptions in a state that actually can be useful to scholarship. This represents more of a problem with effort than with skill or ability, as the technology has been available for many years. As a result, I have seen the need to re-draw—by hand, electronically—every one of the inscriptions included here, using as many photographs as possible to achieve this goal. Whenever possible, inscriptions themselves were viewed and photographed in person.

Whenever profitable, the drawings were created in composite form, implying the tracing of various photographs for one inscription. The program of choice was Microsoft's PowerPoint, both because of the versatility of its component features and the ability to vary the view of any photo with magnification up to 400%. As a result, letters were drawn at varying magnification, depending on variables such as resolution, brightness, clarity in the writing of pictographs, anomalous markings on the stone surrounding or encountering the strokes of the pictographs, and damage due to weathering. Only such an investment of time, effort, and technology can lead to an accurate representation of what the ancient authors originally executed onto their preferred writing surfaces.

The intention here was not to compile an exhaustive study of every PCH inscription in existence, which could not be achieved in one volume even if desired. Instead, effort was made to limit the study to the vast majority of inscriptions that are complete or long enough to render a comprehensible and coherent message, one that can be derived with relative or great confidence. A work such as this has never been attempted, so there is no guarantee that I have rendered every pictograph accurately, transliterated every letter into Hebrew correctly, divided letters into words properly, or translated every word / clause / sentence / inscription optimally.

However, great caution was exercised to complete the task of drawing inscriptions fully and accurately, transcribing letters faithfully, and translating confidently before completing the writing of this volume, so as not to rush to press prematurely. As a result of this exacting approach to the task, the hope is that this work will withstand both the necessary rigors of scholarly scrutiny and the annals of time. Final judgment as to the accuracy of its findings should be reserved for three, four, or five decades after publication, not determined hastily. In the words of the German philosopher, Arthur Schopenhauer, “All truth passes through three stages. First, it is ridiculed. Second, it is violently opposed. Third, it is accepted as being self-evident.” The assurance that I can provide regarding the inscriptions and their translations is that I had no horse in this race. However the text was found to read, that is how it was translated, with no attempt whatsoever at undue embellishment or incorporation of personal bias.

Due to the polarizing nature of the ramifications of this book, especially in relation to its impact on various aspects of biblical historicity, the expectation—though certainly not my desire—is that this volume will not lack for controversy. For this reason, it would have been far simpler to forego publication and leave this burden to some other brave soul who also is an interdisciplinarian, with training in Western Semitic languages, biblical Hebrew grammar and exegesis, Syro-Palestinian archaeology, Middle Egyptian language, Egyptian archaeology, iconography, and epigraphy (“the study of ancient texts and inscriptions”; see Yardeni 2014: 3). However, choosing this route would do a great disservice both to the ancient Hebrew writers who intended to communicate their thoughts and sentiments for posterity, to all of the professors and scholars (in various fields) who have invested so much in me, and to all of those who can and will benefit personally from the book’s publication. In short, it would be unforgivably self-centered and short-sighted to shirk the responsibility that has been placed on my shoulders, despite the impending controversy.

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September 2016

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I also am indebted to Brian Colless, who deeply stimulated my thinking in the area of Western Semitics, syllabics, and the proto-consonantal script, even though agreement with him on all matters was not always achieved. Without many of the eye-opening insights that Brian freely offered, the discoveries recorded in this book may never have been spawned. Brian’s own translation of the Lahun Bilingual Ostrakon provided the foundation on which its translation here was built. Profound thanks go to all of the students whom I have taught over the years, from at least 30 different courses taught in three countries. Perhaps unbeknownst to them, their hunger for learning and the application of it to what they have learned has been a motivating factor for me.

With modern technology, scholars can interact with one another instantaneously from all over the world. On account of this, thanks go to numerous scholars on the ANE-2 and EEF online lists who provided insights and bibliographic resources, gave feedback about various readings and hypotheses, and helped to clarify areas of uncertainty. They filled this role without even knowing the great benefit that they would be providing for the present volume. Thanks also go to my family members, friends, and acquaintances who shared in the joy of the pioneering discoveries that were made along the way during the research phase, which kept the creative juices flowing and helped me focus on the final goal of comprehensive understanding and publication for the world to experience the ancient treasures into which this journey has led me.

An enormous debt of gratitude goes to Craig Petrovich, my brother, whose eye for detail with the nuances of Hebrew language and grammar have eliminated dozens of errors that otherwise would plague me relentlessly after publication. Craig graciously offered to check the translation, transcription, and grammatical soundness of every Hebrew construction. “A friend loves at all times, but a brother is born for adversity” ([Prov 17:17](#)). Any mistakes that remain are fully my responsibility, and hopefully will be removed from the second edition, should the need for one arise in the future.

In addition to the technical work that went into the preparation of this volume, tangible resources also were invested, without which its publication would not have come to fruition. I would like to express sincere thanks to all of the following individuals who made substantial contributions to ensure that publication would be achieved: Gerald & Marge Petrovich, Kristin Haines, Corey Linquist, Del Brunning, Jacquie Williams, Robert Adourian, G. M. Grena, and Peggy & George Consolver. Their belief in me and in the importance of this work means more than words can express.

Thanks must be conveyed to the publishers, Carta Jerusalem, namely Emanuel and

Shay Hausman, who from the beginning were impressed with the research involved and by the documentation provided for this project and the wide gamut of my interests. Thanks also go to Barbara Ball, whose diligent editing of the text and unending patience with me have ensured that the manuscript is much more presentable to the reader, and to Lorraine Kessel for the map work. Due to the controversial nature of the material and conclusions in this book, and to the potentially antithetical response that may come from those whose published views and stated convictions may be compromised by the veracity of the book's contents, the publishers have respected my right to present my case freely, and so face the inevitable opposition that will ensue.

In addition to the acknowledgment of the individuals named above, I am truly grateful to Sarah Doherty for her vitally important contribution, which firmly dates the proto-consonantal script's usage to a time late in Egypt's Dynasty 12 (nineteenth century BC). Her expertise in the area of Egyptian ceramics has proven to be an invaluable asset to the present work, complementing the epigraphical contributions in a way that I cannot rival.

D. N. P.

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S. K. D.

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